

CRIBBAGE

Cribbage is a two-player card game in which the primary goal is to be the first to peg 121 points on a cribbage board. Points are scored in three phases: the deal (crib), the pegging phase (playing out cards alternately), and the show (hand counting after play). Attributed to the poet Sir John Suckling (England, early 17th century).

THE CRIBBAGE BOARD

Each player has a track of 120 holes (pegging twice around a 60-hole board) plus a game hole at 121. Two pegs per player allow tracking from 0 to 121. The game ends immediately when any player's front peg reaches or passes hole 121.

CARD VALUES

- ♦ **Number cards (A–10):** Face value (Ace = 1).
- ♦ **Face cards (J, Q, K):** All worth 10.
- ♦ **Ranking** (for sequences and cutting): A, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, J, Q, K (Ace is always low).

DEAL

Deal 6 cards each. Each player discards 2 cards face-down to the crib — a second hand owned by the dealer. The crib is scored by the dealer at the end of the round.

Strategy note: The non-dealer (pone) generally avoids giving good cards to the crib; the dealer welcomes strong crib contributions.

THE CUT (STARTER CARD)

After discarding, the non-dealer cuts the remaining deck. The dealer reveals the top card of the lower half — this is the **starter card** (also called the turn-up). It is used in scoring all hands during the show.

Nibs (Heels): If the starter card is a Jack, the dealer immediately pegs 2 points (“Two for his heels”).

PEGGING PHASE

Alternating starting with the non-dealer, players lay cards one at a time face-up, calling out the cumulative running total (never exceeding 31).

Pegging scores during play:

EVENT	POINTS
Reaching exactly 15 (cumulative total)	2
Reaching exactly 31	2
“Go” (opponent cannot play without exceeding 31)	1
Last card played (if total is not 31)	1
Pair (consecutive same-rank card)	2
Three of a kind (three consecutive same rank)	6
Four of a kind (four consecutive same rank)	12
Run of 3 (consecutive ranks in last 3+ cards played)	3
Run of 4	4
Run of 5	5

Go rule: When a player cannot play without exceeding 31, they say “Go.” The opponent continues playing cards if they can. After a Go (or when 31 is reached), the running total resets to 0 and the player who did not last play begins a new sequence.

THE SHOW (HAND SCORING)

After pegging, players score their hands using the starter card as a fifth card. The pone (non-dealer) scores first, then the dealer, then the dealer scores the crib.

Scoring combinations (each combination scores separately):

COMBINATION	POINTS	NOTES
Fifteen: Any combination of cards summing to 15	2 per fifteen	Ace=1, J/Q/K=10
Pair: Two cards of the same rank	2 per pair	
Pair Royal (Three of a kind):	6 (three pairs)	
Double Pair Royal (Four of a kind):	12 (six pairs)	
Run of 3: Three cards in sequence	3	
Run of 4: Four cards in sequence	4	
Run of 5: Five cards in sequence	5	
Flush (4 cards same suit in hand):	4	Starter card not required. Not counted in crib unless all 5 cards match.
Flush (5 cards same suit, including starter):	5	
Nobs: Jack of same suit as starter card	1	One Jack in hand matching starter suit.

Maximum hand: 29 points (three 5s and a Jack in hand, starter is the 5 of the same suit as the Jack — allowing 8 fifteens, 6 pairs, one nobs).

MUGGINS (OPTIONAL)

If a player fails to peg points they earned, the opponent may call “Muggins” and claim those points. Commonly used in competitive play; optional in casual games.

GAME VARIANTS

Three-player Cribbage: 5 cards dealt each, 1 discarded to crib; extra card dealt directly to crib. Play proceeds clockwise. First to 121 wins.

Four-player Cribbage: Teams of two (partners sitting opposite). 5 cards each, 1 discarded to crib. Partners’ scores are combined. First team to 121 wins.

Six-card Cribbage: Standard two-player game where 6 cards are dealt and 2 are discarded to the crib (same as standard rules above).

ATTRIBUTION

Cribbage. Attributed to Sir John Suckling, England, early 17th century. Public domain. Standard rules confirmed from Pagat.com and the American Cribbage Congress.